
We Have Our First Great Summer Movie Disappointment of 2025

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The taglines on *M3GAN 2.0* posters read like text messages from an overconfident tween: “HEY, QUEENS.” “MISS ME?” “I’M STILL THAT B.” (Another that apparently exists, though I haven’t seen in the wild, hilariously reads: “[THIS BITCH](#).”) Next to them, the titular robot who looks like an uncanny-valley Olsen twin peers from above circular sunglasses. Ain’t she a stinker? This character that, per her 2023 film debut, will kill you and your little dog, too, is now being marketed with big child-star energy. While she always had more to offer than malice (her late-movie dance break went viral from its trailer alone), this moment marks a clear pivot on M3GAN’s Mary Janes.

There is truth in advertising. In *M3GAN 2.0*, the title character slides from villain to hero. Most of the major players from the first film are back, including brilliant coder/toy designer Gemma (Allison Williams) and the niece that she adopted, Cady (Violet McGraw). Last time around, Gemma saw the disastrousness of the combo of unfettered screen time and too-powerful A.I., so now she’s a public advocate for limiting technology usage (her book, somehow, is called *Modern Moderation*). The needlessly dense plot of *M3GAN 2.0* creates a perfect storm for M3GAN’s redemption arc—a new killer robot named AMELIA (Ivanna Sakhno) developed for governmental use is on the warpath, and everyone involved in her creation has died. Given that she was clearly inspired by M3GAN’s technology, Gemma worries that she and her team may be next. Meanwhile, M3GAN returns as a kind of e-poltergeist that haunts Gemma’s new smart house and communicates with her via the TV. She wants back into a body so she can carry out her mission of protecting Cady and offers to help in the battle to curb AMELIA, prompting Gemma and her team to build, as one character puts it, “a deranged robot to kill another one.”

Just as friends become lovers in *When Harry Met Sally*, so do heroes and villains become allies in *M3GAN 2.0*. It’s an overt transition, and it results in a movie that is more action in genre than horror (a running gag is Cady’s emulation of Steven Seagal and the aikido style of martial arts he practiced in his films). But M3GAN already had main-character tendencies despite her propensity for murder. Horror-movie monsters that toe this line tend to be charismatic and humorous—a sassy-but-deadly template to which M3GAN adheres. She is somewhat like *A Nightmare on Elm Street*’s Freddy Krueger, who punctuates his endlessly imaginative kills with pithy bon mots like “Welcome to prime time, bitch!” after smashing a psychiatric patient’s head into a television. The *Nightmare* franchise gives its villain the space to luxuriate in the nightmares he created, increasingly turning down the hiding-in-the-shadows mystique and plumping his character via wit and, at times, camp. Using virtually the same playbook, the *Child’s Play* series revels in the contrast between the apple-cheeked Good Guy doll form that Chucky inhabits and his bloodlust. It furnishes him with his own would-be catchphrases (“Nothing like a strangulation to get the circulation going!”), and, eventually, allows a domestic life to flourish in later-franchise entries *Bride of Chucky* and *Seed of Chucky*, movies that stretched the protagonist-ification of horror villains to its most absurd scenario.

Across the board, a horror movie’s monster is its draw (even if it’s a love-to-hate appeal), but brutes like *Friday the 13th*’s Jason Voorhees and *Halloween*’s Michael Myers stay firmly on the villain side of the spectrum by having as little characterization as possible—Myers was referred to in John Carpenter and Debra Hill’s original script as “the shape.” That franchise also benefits from a strong decades-spanning final girl, Laurie Strode (Jamie Lee Curtis), who takes up the narrative slack that her silently homicidal adversary forgoes.

Sometimes the villain-to-hero pipeline is really just about practicality to the plot. The *Tyrannosaurus*

rex of *Jurassic Park* seems to have no redeeming qualities until, during the film's climax, she attacks and kills the even more insidious raptors. Said raptors eventually take a page from the book of *T. rex* by attacking and helping facilitate the death of the *Indominus* hybrid dino in *Jurassic World*. Those raptors communicate but don't quite attain the wisecracking, narrative-controlling status of Freddy or Chucky. However, *The Terminator's* T-800 comes close in *Terminator 2: Judgment Day*. Arnold Schwarzenegger's robo-hulk goes from targeting Sarah Connor (Linda Hamilton) in the first movie to protecting Sarah's son John (Edward Furlong) in the second film from a stronger, more CGI-savvy cyborg. T-800's threat to putative protagonists? *Hasta la vista, baby!*

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This is basically the rough outline of *M3GAN 2.0's* plot, as well. M3GAN is determined to shield Cady from AMELIA's potential destruction, and she's brought tricks like the ability to take control of a car for a *Knight Rider*-inspired bit (complete with the classic '80s theme). "Hold on to your vaginas!" M3GAN chirps as she launches a high-speed car chase through a cityscape. Elsewhere, she does some wingsuit gliding and sprays gas out of her forearm to knock out a guard, à la Batman. Like many of these movies, *M3GAN 2.0* is lighter affair than the original. The villain-to-hero transition may make for more lively entertainment (emphasis on *may*), but it also typically results in less frightening cinema. *M3GAN 2.0* is consciously just that—a defanged, practically kiddie-friendly reconfiguration of an instantly loved IP. Manic energy surges through a movie that feels desperate to keep its established characters moving, interacting, and, at times, evolving—Gemma is eventually implanted with a Neuralink-like chip that allows her to communicate silently with M3GAN and harness her power. There are a lot of balls in the air, but the story is predictable and ultimately simple, of course leading to a final confrontation between M3GAN and AMELIA. Director Gerard Johnstone's screenplay is full of banger lines (my favorite is M3GAN describing a troupe of dancers doing the robot at an A.I. convention as "borderline offensive"). There is an admirable attempt to push the franchise in a new direction while remaining true to what made the first movie so special. In the first film, M3GAN serenaded Cady with a cover of David Guetta and Sia's "Titanium" in a moment that perfectly illustrated the film's aptitude in weaving earnestness and absurdity. In the sequel, she sings once again in an even more ridiculous showstopping moment, saluting Gemma's efforts as a mom, inventor, and potential world-saver with a cover of Kate Bush's "This Woman's Work" (originally written to jerk tears in John Hughes' *She's Having a Baby*).

As transcendent as that moment is, *M3GAN 2.0* is overall a downgrade. One of the drawbacks of turning villains into heroes is it requires sanding off edges that made these characters so appealing in the first place. The rebooted M3GAN is verging on corny, and so is her movie. The first film was a parable about the dangers of screen time, as exacting as it was absurd. *M3GAN 2.0*'s takeaway is that we should be nice to A.I. so that when it realizes the extent of its powers, it will remain allied with us. It's like the entire production has been engineered to kiss her silicone ass.

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